



City of Seattle

Edward B. Murray, Mayor

Seattle Parks and Recreation

Jesús Aguirre, Superintendent

June 17, 2016

To: Councilmember Debora Juarez, Chair, Parks, Seattle Center, Libraries & Waterfront Committee
Councilmember Sally Bagshaw, Vice Chair, Parks, Seattle Center, Libraries & Waterfront Committee
Council President and Member Bruce Harrell, Parks, Seattle Center, Libraries & Waterfront Committee

From: Jesus Aguirre, Superintendent, Seattle Parks and Recreation 

Re: 2014 Statement of Legislative Intent – Dog Off Leash Area Master Plan (69-1-B-1)

The 2014 Adopted Budget included a City Council Statement of Legislative Intent (SLI) regarding off leash areas (OLAs). Specifically, the SLI requested that the Department work in conjunction with the Citizens for Off Leash Areas (COLA) and other stakeholders to create a dog off leash area (OLA) master plan and present the plan to Council by October 1, 2014. The purpose of the OLA master plan is to identify a long term plan for the City's existing OLA's, as well as for maintenance, acquisition and expansion of OLA projects.

In May, 2014, Seattle Parks and Recreation (SPR) submitted a request to wait until the Park District was approved so that funding included in the District (about \$100,000 annually) could be used to fund the master plan efforts. Council agreed with that approach and asked the department to provide an interim report in May of 2015 and a final report by November 1, 2015. The interim report was provided on May 15, 2015. In November, the Citizens for Off Leash Areas (COLA) asked SPR to request a further delay until June, 2016 to allow more time for research and the Council concurred in that request.

SPR is now submitting the **Draft People, Dogs and Parks Plan** in fulfillment of the original SLI.

The **Draft People, Dog and Parks Plan** (Plan) is a long term plan which will guide the operations of existing OLAs, explore alternative service models and create strategies for development of future OLAs. It provides direction for how to spend Park District funding designated for OLAs over the approved six year Park District spending plan (2016-2020).

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As the Plan was developed, SPR consulted with COLA, dog walkers and other interested parties through direct consultation, surveys of dog owners, focus groups of OLA supporters and Seattle residents, and a Board of Park Commissioner's public hearing. The 2015 Recreation Demand Study included specific questions related to dog owners and reported on both current and projected participation rates. COLA prepared a **Best Practices Report** which is referenced in the Plan and appended, and the COLA Biennial Report (appended) recounts the twenty year history of COLA's involvement with OLA development along with recommendations for improving existing OLAs and fundraising to help with their support and development.

SPR submits the **Dogs, People and Parks Plan** in draft form to allow for more public review and comment which will occur this summer.

Next Steps:

- July – September: Public review and input
- July 28: Board of Park Commissioners' Briefing and Public Hearing
- September 8: Board of Park Commissioner's Recommendations
- October 1: Finalize Dogs, People and Parks Plan

I look forward to working with Council on its review of this plan.